

Chapter Title: Bernard Lonergan and the Possibility of a Christian Philosophy

Book Title: Faith and Reason

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Published by: Augsburg Fortress, Fortress Press. (2017)

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/j.ctt1pwt3xs.6>

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Bernard Lonergan and the Possibility of a Christian Philosophy

Bernard Lonergan was one of the outstanding Catholic intellectuals of the twentieth century. While his published outputs during his lifetime was relatively meagre, mainly his two major works, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*,¹ and *Method in Theology*,² these were of such depth and originality as to establish his standing among his peers. It is now only after his death, that the full range of his thinking is being made available through the publication of his *Collected Works*.³ There we can find his thought not only on philosophy and theology but on mathematics and logic, education and art, economics, as well as specialized theological studies on the Trinity, Christology, and grace. Given this range of outputs I cannot hope to cover all aspects of his work. In this chapter I shall focus on three aspects: Lonergan's credentials as a Thomist; his understanding of the relationship between faith and reason, mainly as presented in his book, *Insight* and later writings;

1. Bernard J. F. Lonergan, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, ed. Crowe Frederick E. and Robert M. Doran, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1992).

2. *Method in Theology* (London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1972).

3. This is a major publishing project under the editorship of Robert Doran and published by University of Toronto Press. There are a projected 24 volumes with some 20 already in print.

and finally how we can view Lonergan as a “Christian philosopher” as envisaged by both Gilson and *Fides et ratio*.

Years Reaching Up to the Mind of Aquinas

In the epilogue to his magnum opus, *Insight*, Lonergan speaks of “spending years reaching up to the mind of Aquinas.”⁴ The reference here is not just to the years of study of Thomist texts and their commentators during his training for the priesthood but more specifically to the period of his doctoral studies on the question of grace and freedom, published as a series of articles in *Theological Studies*, and his profound engagement with Thomas’s cognitional and epistemological theories, all undertaken in the context of the Trinitarian psychological analogy, also published as a series of articles in the journal, *Theological Studies*. Both were published as stand-alone volumes,⁵ and both have been republished in the *Collected Works* series published by the University of Toronto Press.⁶ The exegetical history of these various texts, which appeared in journal articles, book form, and in the final critical edition, is too complex to unravel here. For simplicity’s sake, I shall refer to the *Collected Works* editions as the definitive texts.⁷

As Lonergan makes clear, this engagement was not just about gaining mastery of the works of a classic author. More significant than this “objective” achievement was the profound personal transformation that this engagement initiated: “On the one hand, that reaching had changed me profoundly. On the other hand, that change was the essential benefit.”⁸ Lonergan expresses that benefit in terms of “self-appropriation,” a sophisticated self-knowledge of one’s own cognitional operations. I shall return to this theme when we consider *Insight* in more detail below. For the time being I shall turn my attention to these two earlier projects and their contribution to understanding the “mind of Aquinas.”

4. Lonergan, *Insight*, 769.

5. *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas* (London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1971); *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas* (Notre Dame IND: University of Notre Dame Press, 1967).

6. *Grace and Freedom: Operative Grace in the Thought of St. Thomas Aquinas*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2000); *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1997).

7. I do note however that the *Collected Works* volume *Grace and Freedom*, contains critical editions of both the book version and thesis version of Lonergan’s work.

8. *Insight*, 769.

Grace and Freedom

After undertaking undergraduate studies at Heythrop College in scholastic philosophy and teaching at Montreal, Lonergan was sent in 1933 by his superiors to study theology at the Gregorian University in Rome.⁹ After completing his ordination studies, he pursued doctoral work, also at the Gregorian, on the question of the relationship between grace and freedom. In undertaking this topic Lonergan was entering a long-standing debate between Jesuit and Dominican schools of Thomism that had promoted differing interpretations of Thomas on this question.¹⁰ The Jesuit (Molinist) school had stressed human freedom at the expense of divine sovereignty;¹¹ while the Dominican (Banezian) school so stressed divine sovereignty as to threaten the reality of human freedom.¹² Lonergan, a young Jesuit student, entered into this debate, with an open enough mind as to dismiss the Molinist approach within a few months of starting his study.¹³ His researches were also eventually to reject aspects of the Banezian position, but the road was not straightforward. Before exploring the nature of Lonergan's resolution of this historical controversy, however, I would like to draw attention to the two distinct introductions of his project: one in the thesis version, the other in the later book version.¹⁴

The thesis version begins with bemoaning the inability of theologians to find a suitable method that would resolve the long running debate between the Banezian and Molinist schools. Already at this early stage of his career Lonergan displays what becomes his life-long interest in theological method: "Unless a writer can assign a method that of itself tends to greater objectivity than those hitherto employed, his undertaking may well be regarded as superfluous."¹⁵ To discover such a method he turns to consideration of the way in which speculative thought develops, proposing an "a priori scheme that is capable of synthesizing any possible set of historical data irrespective of their time and place," drawn "solely from a consideration of the nature of

9. While studying at Heythrop Lonergan also undertook degrees in mathematics and classics at the University of London. See Frederick E. Crowe, *Lonergan, Outstanding Christian Thinkers* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1992), 6–17.

10. This debate between the rival religious orders had raged for centuries with such ferocity that the pope was forced to intervene to tell each to back down from their mutual recriminations. This debate has parallels with debates in Protestantism between the Calvinists and Arminians.

11. Named after the Jesuit theologian, Luis du Molina (1553–1600).

12. Named after the Dominican theologian, Domingo Banez (1528–1604).

13. See Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom*, xix.

14. The thesis version occurs at *ibid.*, 162–92. The book version occurs at *ibid.*, 3–20.

15. *Ibid.*, 155.

human speculation on a given subject.”¹⁶ While the details of this *a priori* scheme need not detain us, they prefigure Lonergan’s interest in the turn to the subject, attending to the operations present within any process of “human speculation” in order to answer methodological questions.¹⁷ This approach allows him to view Aquinas’s contribution not only within an historical perspective, but within a personal process of Aquinas’s own speculative development.

The introduction to the book version takes a different tack. Rather than immediately raise issues of methodology, it begins with a recapitulation of the grace-nature debate. Beginning with Augustine’s debates with the Pelagians, and moving through Anselm and Peter Lombard, he identifies a pivotal moment in the contribution of Philip the Chancellor of the University of Paris, whose theoretical breakthrough of the formal distinction of grace and nature as two distinct orders paved the way for the systematic exposition of the question of grace and nature in the work of Thomas Aquinas.

While Augustine left a rich legacy of categories in relation to grace (operative, cooperative, actual, habitual, sufficient etc), his account of the grace-nature issue was marred by an empirical account of human nature. For Augustine, human nature was different before the fall, after the fall, and as redeemed in Christ. This referential fluidity creates a speculative problem. What does it mean, for example, to say that Christ took on our human nature? To which nature is it referring? And how do we conceive of the relationship between grace and freedom, when freedom would seem to mean something different in each variant of human nature? What the distinction of the two orders, grace and nature, made possible was the introduction of a more Aristotelian conception of human nature as a fixed metaphysical principle, constitutive of what it means to be human. It remains stable throughout the various states in which we might find ourselves, though the ability of this nature to express and realize its various potentialities may vary in each state. Lonergan refers to this theoretical breakthrough as the “theorem of the supernatural”:

It no more adds to the data of the problem than the Lorentz transformation puts a new constellation in the heavens. What Philip the Chancellor systematically posited was not the supernatural character of grace, for that was already known and acknowledged, but the validity of a line of

16. *Ibid.*, 156.

17. This scheme itself prefigures elements of what will become Lonergan’s notion of a “universal viewpoint” present in *Insight*, 587–91.

reference termed nature. . . . But the whole problem lies in the abstract, in human thinking: the fallacy in early thought had been an unconscious confusion of the metaphysical abstraction "nature" with the concrete data which do not quite correspond.¹⁸

Lonerган is here identifying the power and necessity of a theoretical perspective if one wants to provide solutions to theological problems. To use an example he often referred to, one can speak of "going faster" in a commonsense manner, but if one wants to do mechanics one needs to talk about "acceleration."¹⁹ With the theoretical distinction of grace and nature in place it became possible "(1) to discuss the nature of grace without discussing liberty, (2) to discuss the nature of liberty without discussing grace, and (3) to work out the relations between grace and liberty."²⁰

Both these introductions display a remarkable degree of methodological sophistication for a budding theologian. The first draws our attention to the cognitive aspects of speculative development; it would not be idle speculation to suggest that in some way Lonergan is laying bare his own experience of development in encountering the work of Aquinas. The second lays the ground for what will become a feature of his work in *Insight*—the distinction between descriptive and explanatory understanding. While the first of these will to some extent be transformed into a more comprehensive account of theological method, the second remains a significant yet underappreciated insight within both philosophy and theology.²¹

The actual engagement with the texts of Aquinas is painstaking and detailed, and need not detain us here. The key to Lonergan's resolution to the debate between the Banezian and Molinist positions, however, lies in a clear grasp of the nature of divine transcendence and of the nature of sin and evil as privation. According to Lonergan, the Molinist position failed to grasp the nature of divine transcendence, making God subject to the temporal flow. Hence in reconciling grace and human freedom they needed to limit divine knowledge of "hypothetical future" events.²² But if God is truly transcendent from creation, God

18. *Grace and Freedom*, 17. The reference to the Lorenz transformation is to an important element in Einstein's theory of special relativity. Lonergan's familiarity with science and mathematics is evident.

19. Acceleration is then defined precisely as a second derivative of distance over time.

20. Lonergan, *Method*, 310.

21. Again in terms of personal biography it seems likely that this distinction between descriptive and explanatory accounts arose from Lonergan's first hand familiarity with mathematics and science.

22. Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom*, 111.

is not subject to time. The divine creative act is one and eternal, so that God's knowledge of past, present and future (for us) is complete and infallible. On the other hand God's knowledge, as transcendent and primary cause of being, is not opposed to the genuine secondary causation present within the created order, including the secondary causation of human willing. The fact that God is the primary cause of the will's movement does not negate the genuine secondary causation present when we will to act.²³ How then is God not responsible for human sin (asks the Molinist)? Here we need to clearly grasp the nature of evil as privation. Sin is evil because it lacks the intelligibility proper to being. Since God is the intelligent cause of an intelligible world order, sin is uncaused.

We can know sin as a fact; we cannot place it as an intelligible correlation with other things except *per accidens*; that is, one sin can be correlated with another . . . but the metaphysical surd of sin cannot be related explanatorily or causally with the integers that are objective truth; for sin is really irrational, a departure at once from the ordinance of the divine mind and from the dictate of right reason . . . the *mysterium iniquitatis* is mysterious in itself and objectively, because of a defect of intelligibility.²⁴

It was the Banezian failure to clearly grasp the unintelligibility of evil that ran the risk of making God the cause not only of salvation but of perdition.²⁵ According to Lonergan, Aquinas offers three possibilities in relation to the divine will: what God wills to be; what God wills not to be; and what God forbids, but allows to occur. Sin falls into this third possibility. In this way Lonergan resolves the dispute, rejecting both claimants while positing to reclaim Aquinas's genuine position.

What is remarkable about this solution to the long-standing dispute between the two contesting parties is that it falls completely within the realm of a "natural" theology. The issue at stake is not so much about the supernatural order of grace, as the relationship between divine causality and human freedom that belongs to the natural order. Accordingly to speak of divine transcendence from the created order

23. More recently this same insight has been given by Kathryn Tanner, using the terminology of a "non-competitive" relationship between divine and human freedom. See Kathryn Tanner, *God and Creation in Christian Theology: Tyranny and Empowerment?* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress, 2004), 36–48, 62–64.

24. Lonergan, *Grace and Freedom*, 115.

25. *Ibid.*, 111: "Banez offers to solve [the problem of grace and freedom] by means of a two-lane highway: along one lane there is what God effects, and that must be; along the other lane is what God does not effect, and that cannot be." The Banezian position comes close to a double predestination as found in Calvin.

and God's universal causality, is a consequence of knowing God as the efficient cause of being, something which falls properly within natural theology known by natural reason.²⁶ Similarly the account of human willing as oriented to an intelligible good, though motivated by a theological context of grace and sin, is itself knowable through natural reason. It belongs to the category of discussing "the nature of liberty without discussing grace." This is even more evident in Lonergan's later work, *Insight*, where he basically reproduces the same arguments in the purely philosophical and natural theological context of that work.²⁷

The work itself is a major achievement for a young theologian grappling with a significant theological problem. David Burrell has described Lonergan's resolution of the debate as definitive and his use of the text of Aquinas "comprehensive."²⁸ In terms of our current project Lonergan's work exemplifies the fruitful conjunction of faith and reason, philosophy and theology. Reason pushes us from description to explanation—in this case drawing on Aquinas's refined Aristotelian metaphysics—to resolve theological issues concerning divine action, grace, and human freedom. While remaining true to its own methods, philosophy has provided invaluable assistance to the theological analysis of the question, strengthening the theological outcome without either faith overriding reason, or reason dominating faith. The dance of faith and reason is herein perfectly balanced and marvelously fertile.

Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas

Lonergan's second foray into reaching up to the mind of Aquinas, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, is another instance of this dance of faith and reason. Ostensibly the presenting issue is a Trinitarian one, to do with the processions of the Word and Spirit, understood analogously in terms of cognitional and volitional operations within human consciousness. Here Lonergan identifies a range of less than successful attempts to interpret the mind of Aquinas on the question, how are we to understand these two processions? However, in responding to this question Lonergan presents a thorough and detailed account of Aquinas's cognitional and epistemological positions, again with the

26. As defined by the teaching of Vatican I, *De Filius*.

27. Lonergan, *Insight*, 684–87.

28. David Burrell, *Faith and Freedom: An Interfaith Perspective* (Malden, MA: Wiley, 2008), 93, and n. 3.

view to recovering Aquinas's authentic position from the distortions of his lesser interpreters. Indeed so overwhelming is this predominantly philosophical set of concerns that one can easily lose sight of the theological context in which they are being handled.²⁹

The book itself is a collection of articles that had been published in *Theological Studies* in the 1940s. In an introduction to the book, published initially in 1967, Lonergan provided a reflection on the issues the study had to confront. Specifically he identified the tensions between the Aristotelian-Thomistic framework of a metaphysical account of human conscious activities, and a more Augustinian approach based on an interrogation of interiority. The title he gave this introduction was "Subject and Soul." From the perspective of an Aristotelian metaphysics, the *soul* is the form of a living thing to be analyzed in terms of its objects, acts and potencies. From the perspective of Augustinian interiority, the *subject* is a phenomenologically rich field of investigation to be uncovered through self-knowledge gained in inner exploration. The problem, as Lonergan identifies it, is to "find in Aristotle the point of insertion for Augustinian thought."³⁰ The appeal to interior knowledge is quite explicit in Augustine, particularly in *De Trinitate* Book 10, where he is presenting the justification for his psychological analogy for the Trinity.³¹ The question that Lonergan wants to raise is the extent to which both Aristotle and Aquinas will similarly draw on the data of consciousness in their accounts of cognition and volition. This is a startlingly important question in light of the more modern "turn to the subject" which we have seen Gilson vehemently rejects.

Equally startling is that Lonergan's starting point in the main body of the text is not a question about the procession of the Word, but of the procession of the Spirit. Here he notes the conclusion of a study by M. T.-L. Pendio, that theologians who have studied the matter of the Spirit's procession fall into two categories: "those who did not pretend to grasp the matter and those who did [pretend] but failed to be convincing."³² Nonetheless Lonergan proposes that the solution to this problem is to be found though an investigation of the related and prior question of the procession of the Word. In relation to this procession

29. In fact in the first edition of the work published in 1967, the first opening paragraphs found in the Collected Works volume, where Lonergan sets the Trinitarian context of his study, did not appear. This may explain why some readers of his work often neglect its Trinitarian depths.

30. Lonergan, *Verbum*, 4.

31. Already in Book 8 of *De Trinitate*, Augustine runs his reader through a set of five-finger exercises to familiarise themselves with their own cognitional and volitional operations. Also see the extensive footnotes on this work in Lonergan, *Verbum*, 6–9.

32. *Ibid.*, 12.

he expresses his dismay that some theologians hold that the procession of the word in intellect is the same as a procession within the imagination.³³ This question, the procession of the Word, will dominate the discussion in this work.

At the heart of the problem is the meaning of the term *emanatio intelligibilis*, the intelligible emanation, which Aquinas uses to analogously account for the procession of the divine Word.³⁴ Lonergan analyses this initially in relation to the inner word of definition and understanding. In a telling summary he notes:

The inner word of the human mind emerges at the end of a process of thoughtful inquiry, that, until it emerges, we do not yet understand but are thinking in order to understand, that it emerges simultaneously with the act of understanding; that it is distinct from understanding, that it is a product and effect of understanding, that it is an expression of the cognitive content of the act of understanding, that more perfect the one act of understanding, the more numerous the inner words it embraces in a single view.³⁵

More importantly he notes that arriving at this position does not occur simply from a metaphysical analysis: “to follow Aquinas here one must practice introspective rational psychology.”³⁶ Later in this work he will detail evidence that “from Aristotle Aquinas derived a method of empirical introspection.”³⁷ This is the point of connection between the Aristotelian and Augustinian traditions Lonergan identified in his introduction to the work.

The inner word that emerges from an act of understanding is thus “caused” by the understanding itself. But what is the nature of this causation that Aquinas characterizes as an intelligible emanation? In particular what is the meaning of the term “intelligible” here? After all, all causation is intelligible, the intelligible dependence of the effect on its cause. What distinguishes this form of causation is not that it is simply intelligible, but that it is intelligent, under the intelligent control of the subject:

33. *Ibid.*

34. *STh I* q27.

35. Lonergan, *Verbum*, 22–24. The fact that this relatively short quote is spread over three pages is indicative of the depth of footnoting Lonergan uses to back these assertions in the text of Aquinas.

36. *Ibid.*, 24.

37. *Ibid.*, 87. He details the evidence over the following pages, 87–93.

Natures act intelligibly, not because they are intelligent, for they are not, but because they are concretions of divine ideas and a divine plan. On the other hand, the intelligibility of the processions of the inner word is not passive nor potential; it is active and actual; it is intelligible because it is the activity of intelligence in act; it is intelligible not as the possible object of understanding is intelligible, but as understanding itself and the activity of understanding is intelligible.³⁸

The intelligibility of the procession of the word is the intelligibility of intelligence itself, not of a lawfulness imposed from without, but an immanent law in itself. So the word is not just caused, but “because”: because I understand I utter an inner word.³⁹ Understanding the notion of an intelligible emanation is central to understanding how these activities in human consciousness can act as analogues for the procession of the Word and Spirit in the Trinity. Moreover, the notion is applicable not only to the procession of the word from an act of understanding, but also in judgments and acts in the will in relation to such judgments.

While all can acknowledge the scholarly depth of engagement with Aquinas, which is so evident in Lonergan’s work here, there has been something of a cleavage in terms of its reception. This is not surprising given, as Lonergan himself has noted, the major historical divisions present within Thomistic scholarship. These divisions arise from certain prior preconceptions which in his later work Lonergan will speak of in terms of one’s horizon, and where major changes in one’s horizon amount to a “conversion,” in particular in dealing with cognitional and related epistemological and metaphysical issues, with intellectual conversion. And so while Douglas Hall will argue that Lonergan overcame “centuries of misinterpretation with boldly insightful yet historically grounded analyses”⁴⁰ and Anthony Kenny finds Lonergan’s work in *Verbum* one “of the most illuminating books about Aquinas’ work in this area”⁴¹, others have been less generous. In an early article in *The Modern Schoolman* Matthew O’Connell launched a scathing attack

38. *Ibid.*, 47.

39. An example Lonergan often uses relates to the definition of the circle. One may simply repeat the definition, not because one understands, but simply because one has been taught it; but for the one who understands the definition emerges from the understanding, and is not just repeated from memory. Every teacher of mathematics knows the difference between students that work from memory and those that genuinely understand.

40. Douglas C. Hall, *The Trinity: An Analysis of St. Thomas Aquinas’ “Expositio” of the “De Trinitate” of Boethius* (Leiden: Brill, 1992), 2.

41. Anthony Kenny, *Aquinas on Mind* (Routledge, 2013), in the preface. I should also mention the Gilsonian scholar, Gaven Kerr, “Aquinas, Lonergan, and the Isomorphism between Intellect and Reality,” *International Philosophical Quarterly* 54, no. 1 (2014): 43–57, who while critical of Lonergan’s

on Lonergan's interpretation of Aquinas.⁴² More recently John Milbank has been highly critical of Lonergan's work, but there are good grounds for holding that he understands neither Lonergan's position on Aquinas, nor Aquinas himself.⁴³

The Transposition to the Modern Context – Lonergan's *Insight*

If these two studies represent Lonergan's immersion in the thought world of Aquinas, his major study, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, is the fruit of that immersion brought into engagement with the modern world. Two major aspects of that engagement are with modern science (at the time of Lonergan's writing, science up to the mid-1950s) and modern philosophy (notably with Kant and Hegel). However, while the work is the fruit of his immersion in Aquinas, the latter is hardly present in the text except occasionally and parenthetically. Aquinas is not an authority to be quoted to establish a case, though he has an honored place in the history of philosophy as Lonergan understands it. Rather we have Lonergan speaking definitively in his own voice as a philosopher, on a range of topics: science; common sense; society; cognitional, epistemological and metaphysical issues; ethics; and finally natural theology. Lonergan is not attempting to say what Aquinas might have said if he were alive today, but to say what Lonergan holds in transposing Aquinas into the present context.⁴⁴

In terms of the nature of the present project on the possibility of a Christian philosophy, Lonergan's work in *Insight* is important because as was noted earlier in chapter 1, if we are to give a coherent account of the relationship between faith and reason, one thing we need to do

metaphysical claims, finds Lonergan's account of Aquinas on cognitional theory "consistent and coherent" (57).

42. Matthew J. O'Connell, "St Thomas and the Verbum: An Interpretation," *Modern Schoolman* 24 (1946-47): 224-34. O'Connell's opening lines are: "In a recent article in *Theological Studies*, there appeared an article concerning St Thomas's doctrine on the verbum. It is of interest to Thomistic philosophers as an example of how easily a concatenation of text from St Thomas can easily be made to support a theory he could never have accepted" (224). For an effective rebuttal of O'Connell's position see J. Quentin Lauer, "Comment on 'An Interpretation,'" *Modern Schoolman* 25 (1947-48): 251-59. O'Connell was responding to the first of the verbum articles that appeared in *Theological Studies*. Lonergan was later to footnote O'Connell's article in his later articles as representing "the other side of the ledger." See Lonergan, *Verbum*, 107n2.

43. See the major rebuttal by Paul J. DeHart, *Aquinas and Radical Orthodoxy: A Critical Inquiry* (New York: Routledge, 2012). Less extensively, see Neil Ormerod, "'It is Easy to See': The Footnotes of John Milbank," *Philosophy and Theology* 11, no. 2 (1999): 257-64.

44. On Lonergan's notion of transposition see Christiaan Jacobs-Vandegeer, "The Hermeneutics of Interiority: Transpositions in the Third Stage of Meaning," in *Meaning and History in Systematic Theology: Essays in Honor of Robert Doran, SJ*, ed. John Dadosky (Milwaukee: Marquette University Press, 2009).

is sort out what exactly we mean by reason itself. Without a genuinely explanatory account of reason, any attempt to either oppose faith and reason, or subsume one within the other, will rest on little more than assertion and counter-assertion. Just as in *Grace and Freedom*, where Lonergan identified the three-fold task of (1) discussing the nature of grace without discussing liberty, (2) discussing the nature of liberty without discussing grace, and (3) working out the relations between grace and liberty, so too unless we have a thorough account of the nature of reason, we will be hard pressed to give a solid analysis of the relationship between faith and reason.

For Lonergan the key to all philosophy is nothing less than an understanding of understanding. We have already witnessed how his account of Aquinas's notion of an intelligible emanation was the key to understanding the underlying cognitional theory behind the psychological analogy for the Trinity. Here that same issue becomes the key to all knowledge: "*Thoroughly understand what it is to understand, and not only will you understand the broad lines of all there is to be understood but also you will possess a fixed base, an invariant pattern, opening upon all further developments of understanding.*" This sums up the "positive content" of his book.⁴⁵ Again, however, our purpose will not be to explore all the riches of this major work, but to focus on those elements of particular relevance to our exploration of the possibility of a Christian philosophy.

Modern Science

Many a reader has been put off reading *Insight* because of the demands made in the first five chapters.⁴⁶ Here Lonergan draws on mathematical and scientific examples that those with no facility in the area may find alienating. He begins with an account of insight drawing on the example of Archimedes jumping out of his bath shouting eureka and running naked down the streets of Syracuse. He moves quickly to the definition of the circle, and then to arithmetic, algebra, nominal and implicit definitions (a favorite tool of the mathematician David Hilbert), inverse insights (which grasp that there is no direct insight to be gained and so one must seek a higher viewpoint), and the notion of the empirical residue (the residual data from which science abstracts).⁴⁷ Throughout this journey Lonergan is asking us to attend

45. Lonergan, *Insight*, 22. Emphasis in the original.

46. Anecdotally this appears to be one reason for Lonergan's reputation for being "difficult" to read.

47. All this is introduced in chapter 1, Lonergan, *Insight*, 27–56.

to our own performance as subjects experiencing insights, in all their variety. As the title of the first section of the book explains, it is concerned with “Insight as Activity.”⁴⁸

This focus on insight as activity then turns our attention for the next four chapters to questions of science: scientific understanding and its method. Using his distinction between direct and inverse insights Lonergan distinguishes between classical scientific accounts, wherein there are direct correlations between variables,⁴⁹ and statistical scientific accounts, wherein the correlations are of a statistical nature.⁵⁰ In both cases, classical and statistical laws, there is an intelligibility found in the data, though that intelligibility differs in each case. He then argues that these two types of scientific laws are complementary, that both are needed and both combine to produce what he calls schemes of recurrence, leading to his notion of emergent probability, a generalized form of evolutionary thinking.⁵¹ Finally, in Chapter 5, drawing on the notion of insight and the necessary invariance of physical laws, he provides a philosophical analysis of special and general relativity.⁵²

All this is an intellectual *tour de force* and on its own would be enough to establish Lonergan as an original and profound philosopher of science. Lonergan speaks of science and mathematics as someone with a genuine feel for his topic. However, *Insight* is not a work in the philosophy of science but in cognitional theory. Lonergan takes his reader through this material because it allows him to stretch out the various components of cognitional activity.⁵³ Science requires that we attend to the data; in struggling to understand this data we experience insights that are formulated as hypotheses, often in mathematical form; these hypotheses must then be subject to verification and judgment as to their validity. These three elements, experience (attending to the data), understanding, and judgment become a refrain throughout the work. They were present in Lonergan’s account of Aquinas’s

48. With this starting point Lonergan is not trying to justify knowing. He takes knowing as given and asks about its processes. Thus his starting point is not scepticism about knowing as in Descartes.

49. Lonergan, *Insight*, 60–76. One might think of the scientific paradigms of Newton and Einstein, often associated with a deterministic understanding of scientific laws.

50. *Ibid.*, 76–92. One might think here of areas such as quantum mechanics or evolution where there appears to be an irreducibly statistical component to the laws they enunciate.

51. *Ibid.*, 126–62. For an account of these notions and their implications in contemporary science and religious debates see Neil Ormerod and Cynthia S. W. Crysdale, *Creator God, Evolving World* (Minneapolis, MN: Fortress Press, 2013).

52. Lonergan, *Insight*, 163–95.

53. Bernard J. F. Lonergan et al., *Caring about Meaning: Patterns in the Life of Bernard Lonergan* (Montreal: Thomas More Institute, 1982), 221.

cognitional theory, but here they are presented through an analysis of modern science and its method.

The other hard gained goal of this material is the distinction between descriptive and explanatory insight. Descriptive insights relate things to us, while explanatory insights relate things to other things. The explanatory power of science lies in its movement from descriptive to explanatory insights, to develop hypotheses that relate things to other things. Lonergan already refers to this movement in his introductory material in *Grace and Freedom* in his discussion of the theorem of the supernatural. Here we come closer to the source of this distinction in his familiarity with science and mathematics. Both these disciplines are able to advance by moving from descriptive accounts to provide a tight control of meaning of their basic terms and relations which are mutually defined.⁵⁴ This approach is the notion of implicit definition, something Lonergan learnt from the mathematician David Hilbert.⁵⁵

Cognitional Theory

These three elements (experience, understanding, and judgment) become the basic components of Lonergan's account of cognition. Each of these activities is a conscious activity, that is, they relate to operations we perform while conscious, not asleep or in a coma.⁵⁶ We become familiar with our cognitional operations through attending to them as conscious operations. Still this is not a Cartesian withdrawal from the world to contemplate ourselves through some inward look. Rather it is a heightening of consciousness to attend to its operations while they are occurring. We experience ourselves having an insight: we experience the struggle to understand, the sudden and at times unexpected arrival of the insight, the falling into place of the pieces of the puzzle, the release of tension that accompanies its arrival. I can so attend

54. This is very evident in the so-called Standard Model of particle physics where particles and fields are defined in terms of their mutual relations to one another. See Robert Oerter, *The Theory of Almost Everything: The Standard Model, the Unsung Triumph of Modern Physics* (New York: Penguin Group US, 2006).

55. William A. Mathews, *Lonergan's Quest: A Study of Desire in the Authoring of Insight* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2005), notes "Lonergan's style is heavily mathematical, the method of implicit definition developed by Hilbert, the mathematician, being constantly in the background" (12).

56. Lonergan distinguishes between "consciousness as presence" and "consciousness as perception." Lonergan, *Insight*, 344–46. When these are confused it leads to various incoherencies in one's account of consciousness. When Lonergan uses the term consciousness he is always referring to consciousness as presence.

to these experiences because insight is a *conscious* operation and it is *my* insight.⁵⁷ Lonergan will refer to these three types of activities as corresponding to levels of consciousness—experiential, intelligent and rational consciousness. Each “higher” level subsumes or sublates the “lower” level, not leaving behind the prior levels but taking them into a larger richer context.⁵⁸

Lonergan spends two chapters spelling out in more detail the nature of judgment.⁵⁹ If insight arises in relation to the question “what is it?” judgment arises as we move through the insight and its conceptual formulation to ask “is it so?” If we attend to this process we can notice that the referents in these two questions are different. When we ask “what is it?” the referent “it” relates to a particular set of data which we have singled out for attention—a sound, a noise, some visual phenomenon we encounter. However, when we ask “is it so?” the “it” now refers to the intelligibility that arises from the insight in relation to the data. Is this intelligibility truly the intelligibility of the data? Judgments pass judgment on insights in relation to data. Insights are, as Lonergan often notes, “a dime a dozen.”⁶⁰ The same desire to know that drives our initial question about the nature of the experience now pushes us to seek to verify our insights as true or false. The question is, how do we make such judgments? What are the cognitional steps we engage to reach the point where we say yes or no? It is important to note that this is not an epistemological question about the validity of judgments, but first and foremost a question of cognitional performance. What am I doing in making a judgment?

Of course there are all sorts of judgments that we make: common-sense judgments, scientific judgments, mathematical judgments and so on. In order to uncover the basic pattern of all these judgments, Lonergan draws our attention to the basic form of the syllogism:

If A, then B
But A
Therefore B.

57. This notion of the self-presence of the subject in their own cognitional activity is also present in Augustine, *De Trinitate*, Book 10.

58. Lonergan introduces the notion of sublation to describe this relationship between levels of consciousness in his later work, Lonergan, *Method*, 241.

59. David Tracy notes that many commentators think that Lonergan’s work on judgment is among the more original of his contributions to cognitional theory. See David Tracy, *The Achievement of Bernard Lonergan* (Herder and Herder, 1970), 128.

60. Frederick E. Crowe, *Developing the Lonergan Legacy: Historical, Theoretical and Existential Themes*, ed. Michael Vertin (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004), 281.

The point is not to try to make cognition a logical deductive process as is often meant when people refer to “reason” or “rationality.” Such would be a severe misunderstanding of Lonergan’s point. Rather as he states:

Now the conclusion is a conditioned, for an argument is needed to support it. The major premise links this conditioned to its conditions, for it affirms ‘If A, then B.’ The minor premise presents the fulfilment of the conditions, for it affirms the antecedent A. The function, then, of the form of deductive inference is to exhibit a conclusion as virtually unconditioned. Reflective insight grasps the pattern, and by rational compulsion there follows the judgment.⁶¹

The conclusion, B, is a condition whose conditions have been fulfilled; in Lonergan’s terms, it is a “virtually unconditioned.” The terminus of the cognitional process lies in a different type of insight, not direct or inverse, but reflective, which grasps that there is a connection between the conclusion and the conditions to be fulfilled, and in fact they are fulfilled. Still if the conclusion is a judgment, we cannot think of the premise and minor premise as also representing judgments or we end up with an infinite regression of prior judgments. Rather,

Before the link between conditioned and conditions appears in the act of judgment, it existed in a more rudimentary state within cognitional process itself. Before the fulfilment of conditions appears in another act of judgment, it too was present in a more rudimentary state within cognitional process. The remarkable fact about reflective insight is that it can make use of those more rudimentary elements in cognitional process to reach the virtually unconditioned.⁶²

The operative criterion for the termination of the cognitional process leading to judgment is located in the distinction between vulnerable and invulnerable insights. Insights are invulnerable when there are no further relevant questions to be asked. Once this stage is reached a judgment is a matter of “rational compulsion.”⁶³ Still as Lonergan notes, the judgment is a personal act and commitment. As he notes, “everyone complains of his memory, but no one of his judgment.”⁶⁴ Rational compulsion does not make it automatic. Just as some may

61. Lonergan, *Insight*, 306.

62. Ibid.

63. Or in the earlier terminology of *Verbum*, this is an intelligible emanation.

64. Lonergan, *Insight*, 297.

judge hastily, jumping the gun before their insight is invulnerable; while others may delay judgment because they fear error.

One may trace Lonergan's account of judgment to antecedents in John Henry Newman, in particular his *Grammar of Assent*.⁶⁵ Lonergan notes that he read sections of Newman's essay several times, notably those sections where Newman speaks of the "illative sense."⁶⁶ As with Lonergan, Newman is searching for the cognitive criterion by which we come to a judgment. Newman too is very aware of the personal nature of judgment, and the finely balanced process by which a judgment is formed. Lonergan adds precision to Newman's account through his distinction between vulnerable and invulnerable insight.

With the addition of judgment we arrive at the basic outline of Lonergan's cognitional theory. We move through experience, through inquiry to insight and formulation, to reflective insight and judgment. At this stage cognitional process has come to its term. Once we reach a judgment we can say we know. This does not tell us what we know or why this process is knowing, but an account of knowing as an *activity*. Lonergan makes two strong claims in relation to his account of the structure of cognitional activity. The first is that it is self-verifiable. In Chapter 11 of *Insight*, entitled "Self-affirmation of the knower," he asks his readers to affirm themselves as knowers through this three-fold structure. This involves: experiencing oneself as experiencing, understanding and judging; understanding oneself as experiencing, understanding and judging; and judging oneself as experiencing, understanding and judging. Each of us, he claims, is able to affirm ourselves as a knower engaged in experiencing, understanding, and judging. For Lonergan this three-fold structure defines what it means to know. This claim is the climax of the first half of the book, and initiates a transition from insight as *activity* to insight as *knowledge*.

The second claim is that this structure is irrevisable. He asks his reader to suppose how one might propose a revision to the structure. First, one would point out some data which the structure overlooks. Then one would propose a different understanding on the basis of the new data. Finally, one would propose that there is sufficient evidence to pass a judgment that this proposed revision is superior to the old proposal. However, in doing so one would be implicitly adopting Lonergan's structure of experience, understanding and judgment. Any

65. John Henry Newman, *An Essay in Aid of a Grammar of Assent* (London: Burns, Oates and Co, 1874), Chapter 9.

66. Lonergan et al., *Caring about Meaning*, 45–46, 107.

proposed revision would thus implicitly affirm what explicitly it was denying. This would be a performative contradiction, a contradiction between one's performance and one's claim made in the act of performance. Philosophically this is referred to as a retortion argument.

This explication of the structure of cognitional activity fulfils what Lonergan identifies as the main goal of his book, to find "*a fixed base, an invariant pattern, opening upon all further developments of understanding.*"⁶⁷ Everything else in Lonergan's work revolves around this fixed base. From this base Lonergan will move into metaphysics, epistemology and questions of objectivity.

Knowing, the Known, and Being

To know the structure of knowing is to also know the structure of the known; indeed there is an isomorphism between the knowing and the known.⁶⁸ This assertion is the first step in a movement from questions of cognition to questions of epistemology and metaphysics. While a traditional Thomistic approach, as we found in Gilson, will place enormous emphasis on the priority of metaphysics, Lonergan will seek to ground his metaphysics in his cognitional theory. His argument is that his more precise account of cognitional activity will then allow for a more precise control of metaphysical meaning than Thomism was able to provide.⁶⁹ From cognitional theory Lonergan will develop a *critical* metaphysics.

If knowing consists of experience, understanding, and judgment, then the known has an empirical component grasped in experience, and intelligible component grasped in insight, and a rational component grasped in judgment. To someone trained in Aristotelian-Thomistic metaphysics, this three-fold constitution of the known begins to look like the metaphysical account of being in terms of potency, form, and act. Indeed Lonergan will make this connection when he makes the further claim that the isomorphism of knowing and the known is in fact an isomorphism between knowing and proportionate being, that is, being that is proportionate to our knowing.⁷⁰

67. Lonergan, *Insight*, 22.

68. *Ibid.*

69. As he notes in the Preface to *Insight*, "the philosophy and metaphysics that result from insight into insight will be verifiable." Further, "every statement in philosophy and metaphysics can be shown to imply statements regarding cognitional fact." *Ibid.*, 5.

70. *Ibid.*, 416.

Of course we can ask whether proportionate being is the whole of being, which is to ask about the possible existence of transcendent being, being for which there is no empirical component to be had. But prior to that we must grant that being itself is the goal of all our cognitional activity, whatever can be intelligently grasped and reasonably affirmed. Or as Lonergan puts the matter, being is the objective of the pure desire to know.⁷¹ As he notes, this “definition” is not a concept of being, because to form a concept one must first understand, and to understand being would be to understand everything that is, and this we cannot do. Rather it is a *notion*, an expression of our dynamic, conscious, intelligent and reasonable orientation to being. It tells us not what being is, so much as how we arrive at being, through intelligent grasp and reasonable affirmation. Still, it is an unrestricted notion because we can ask questions about anything and everything, and in asking questions we expect, indeed demand, intelligent and reasonable answers.⁷² It is a spontaneous notion because it arises with the spontaneity of our questioning. In that sense it is prior to whatever philosophical formulations that might arise in relation to being.⁷³ It is an all-pervasive notion because it drives all our cognitional activities: “it underpins all cognitional contents; it penetrates them all; it constitutes them as cognitional.”⁷⁴ Finally it is a puzzling notion, because though it intends the concrete universe of being, of itself the notion is completely indeterminate. Determinacy can only be achieved through specific insights and judgments, which the notion intends, but does not of itself achieve.⁷⁵

At this stage we might be tempted to concede that Gilson’s fears about a transcendental Thomism have been fully realized in Lonergan. Knowing is not defined in terms of being; rather being is defined in terms of knowing. Is this not the very transcendental solipsism that Gilson warned us about? Has idealism excluded any possibility of a genuine realism here? The anxiety behind such questions cannot be pre-emptively dismissed but nonetheless this is a point we do not and cannot concede. In order to address this anxiety we need to push further into the question of reality and objectivity and to do so requires what Lonergan will in his later writings call “intellectual conversion,”

71. *Ibid.*, 372.

72. *Ibid.*, 375–76.

73. *Ibid.*, 377–80.

74. *Ibid.*, 380.

75. *Ibid.*, 383–88.

but which in *Insight* he deals with through what he calls three positions and their corresponding counter-positions.

Intellectual Conversion and Reality

In his later writings Lonergan speaks of the need for an intellectual conversion in terms of a rejection of the “exceedingly stubborn and misleading myth” that reality is already out there now, to be known through taking a good look, and replacing it with reality as the universe of being, known through intelligent grasp and reasonable affirmation.⁷⁶ However, in *Insight*, he does not refer directly to such a conversion. Rather he develops three “positional” claims, which are largely constitutive of what he means by his later term, intellectual conversion. We shall consider each of these positions in turn.⁷⁷

“*The real is the concrete universe of being and not a subdivision of the ‘already out there now’.*”⁷⁸ In the introduction to *Insight* Lonergan speaks of a duality in our knowing, one based on animal extroversion, the other based on a fully human knowing through intelligence and reason.⁷⁹ To the “knowing” of animal extroversion, the world is already out there now, just waiting for us to open our eyes, to sharpen our hearing, to ready our taste buds. It is a world dominated by our animal wants and needs, but it is not a fully human world, a world of institutions, relationships, culture, history and so on. This human world is a real world but it is not known through taking a look, but through intelligence and reason.⁸⁰ The equation of reality with the concrete universe of being, itself defined in terms of the intentionality of our knowing, lies at the heart of intellectual conversion. It involves a radical shift in one’s criteria for reality. As with the self-affirmation of the knower, it is a difficult position to argue against, because any argument is premised upon questions and answers, on intelligence and reason. Once we begin to argue, inasmuch as we do so intelligently and reasonably, we are immediately moving within the universe of being.⁸¹ While we may assert a separation of reality from being (as the objective of the

76. *Method*, 238.

77. In fact Lonergan did use the term “intellectual conversion” in lectures preparatory to *Insight*, but it did not find its way into the published version. See Crowe, *Lonergan*, 68.

78. Lonergan, *Insight*, 413.

79. *Ibid.*, 13.

80. In his later writings Lonergan will refer to this as a world mediated by meaning. See *Method*, 28–29.

81. As Lonergan notes the best way to deal with skeptics is to get them talking. “It is this conditional necessity of contingent fact that involves the talking sceptic in contradiction.” *Insight*, 353.

desire to know), we cannot argue the case without some level of incoherence.

*"The subject becomes known when it affirms itself intelligently and reasonably and so is not known yet in any prior 'existential' state."*⁸² Here Lonergan distinguishes himself from the approach of Descartes. Far from claiming that self-knowledge is some privileged source of knowledge immediately available through an act of introspection, for Lonergan self-knowledge is attained in exactly the same way as all other knowledge, through intelligence and reason. Just as our knowledge of the world begins with the data of sense, our self-knowledge begins with the data of consciousness. For Lonergan consciousness is not self-knowledge, but mere self-presence, which can come to be known through intelligence and reason. To push the matter further, to even distinguish between the data of sense and the data of consciousness requires intelligence and reason to properly make the distinction. This position abolishes the priority of the subject-object split found in idealism and to some extent presumed by Gilson. For Lonergan the distinction is constructed, indeed hard won, not given immediately in the data itself. And as we noted above, access to the data of consciousness is not achieved through a withdrawal from the world of the senses, but is discovered through a heightening of awareness in the act of engagement with the world of the senses.

*"Objectivity is conceived as a consequence of intelligent inquiry and critical reflection, and not as a property of vital anticipation, extroversion, and satisfaction."*⁸³ Given Lonergan has abolished the priority of the subject-object split he must also reject the subjectivity-objectivity dichotomy. If we reject the first and second position, objectivity means knowing the already out there now real through taking a good look and seeing what there is to be seen, and of course, not seeing what isn't there to be seen. Objectivity is then a function of extroversion and one appeals to objectivity over and against subjectivity. However, if one adopts the first and second positions, it would be inconsistent to conceive of objectivity in the terms one has rejected in those positions. Objectivity can only be conceived in terms of allowing the desire to know its full intention, through intelligent inquiry and critical reflection. As these are the activities of the human subject they are "subjective" but not merely subjective in the sense of arbitrary or self-serving. What is opposed to objectivity is not the fact that the operations of intelligence

82. *Ibid.*, 413.

83. *Ibid.*

and reason are those of a conscious subject, but the elements within the subject that interfere with the proper operation of intelligence and reason. These elements are the biases which turn away from particular data, truncate the scope of our questioning, and terminate the knowing process before it has come to its proper term.⁸⁴ Or as Lonergan so succinctly puts the matter in his later writings, “genuine objectivity is the fruit of authentic subjectivity.”⁸⁵

A Lonerganian response to the Gilsonian concern would be to suggest that this concern arises inasmuch as one has not clarified the distinction between animal and fully human knowing, so that the real remains the already out there now real of extroverted consciousness; that one has incorrectly accepted that the subject-object split as primordial rather than constructed by intelligence and reason; and so one is still operating with a false notion of objectivity conceived in terms of extroversion.⁸⁶ I shall argue this more fully in the next chapter.

General and Special Transcendent Knowledge

We have already introduced the distinction between being in general as the objective of the pure desire to know, and proportionate being, that is, being proportionate to our knowing. Human knowledge always begins with the empirical, the data of the senses or the data of consciousness. Interrogation of the data leads to insight, hypothesis/concept, asking the further question “is it so?” to the formation of judgment—yes/no/maybe. The question that naturally arises for an inquiring mind is whether there is any being other than proportionate being? Is there being that transcends the limits of human knowing and if so are we able to know of the existence of such being which by definition transcends the normal structure of that knowing? To raise such a question is to raise the question of God. In two chapters at the conclusion of *Insight*, Lonergan addresses the question of God (chapter 19: General Transcendent Knowledge) and the question of God in relation to the problem of evil (chapter 20: Special Transcendent Knowledge).

To pose the question of God as we have above is to face a conundrum. How can we know the existence of transcendent being when it tran-

84. Lonergan provides a thorough account of these biases as dramatic, individual, group and general, each of which distorts or truncates our orientation to being in specific ways. See *ibid.*, 214–31, 244–67. While important in themselves, they are not necessary for our present work.

85. *Method*, 292.

86. For a solid exposition of the differences see Paul St. Amour, “Lonergan and Gilson on the Problem of Critical Realism,” *Thomist* 69 (2005): 557–92.

scends the normal operation of that knowing? In the current cultural context, the answer is usually a flat rejection of such a possibility. The most common claim is that it is not possible to prove the existence of God, something both Christian theologians and atheists seem to agree upon. However, Lonergan remains faithful to the standard Catholic position that it is possible to know the existence of God and so proceeds to make his argument.⁸⁷ Given the restriction of our knowing to proportionate being, if we are to move to transcendent being it must be through some form of inference based on features of proportionate being that require or even demand further explanation. Such an inference will not be a direct insight into the nature of transcendent being, but rather a judgment of existence based on features of proportionate being. Or as Aquinas would say, we can know that God is, but not what God is.⁸⁸

In order to draw the needed inference Lonergan introduces the notion of causality. True to his method of correlating metaphysical terms with psychological acts, Lonergan defines causality as “the objective and real counterpart of the questions and further questions raised by the detached, disinterested, and unrestricted desire to know.”⁸⁹ Different types of questioning then lead to different types of causality. Internal causes are the metaphysical elements of potency, form and act, while external causes are efficient, final and exemplary causality. While the internal causes relate to proportionate being, the issue that needs resolution is whether the external forms of causality are general principles of being itself. Because being is the objective of the desire to know, being is completely intelligible. For what is unintelligible cannot be, and certainly cannot be the objective of a desire to know. Causality then is not to be conceived in terms of imagined pushes and pulls, or emanations from cause to effect, but as an intelligible relationship of dependence. If we can affirm such an intelligible relationship, then we have a form of causality. If however we restrict the field of causality to the empirical realm of proportionate being, then all our questioning hits up against a brick wall of brute fact—the brute facts of existence and occurrence. If proportionate being is the full scope of being, then being is no longer intelligible in itself, for the brute fact of existence and occurrence allows for no further answers

87. The standard Catholic position was enunciated at Vatican I, and essentially repeated verbatim by Vatican II.

88. Lonergan, *Insight*, 657.

89. *Ibid.*, 674.

to emerge. Ultimately the intelligibility of the realm of proportionate being must lie beyond itself, in a transcendent being who is the external cause of existence of proportionate being.

The summary argument that Lonergan then gives for the existence of God is as follows: "If the real is completely intelligible, God exists. But the real is completely intelligible. Therefore, God exists."⁹⁰ This brings together various elements of Lonergan's overall developing position in *Insight*. The real is completely intelligible because through intellectual conversion we equate the real with being. Being is completely intelligible because we affirm and commit to ourselves as knowers through intelligent grasp and reasonable affirmation.⁹¹ However, the real can only be completely intelligible if there is an extrinsic cause to make it exist, otherwise its incomplete intelligibility means it sinks into non-being. Our commitment to ourselves as fully oriented to being through intelligent grasp and reasonable affirmation commits us to an affirmation of the existence of God.

While there are nuances to the discussion that are beyond the scope of this present exposition, I will make two comments as to the relationship between Lonergan's approach and that of St Thomas.⁹² First, Lonergan notes the similarities between the approach he has adopted above and the well-known "five ways" of Aquinas's *Summa Theologiae*: "the five ways in which Aquinas proves the existence of God are so many particular cases of the general statement that the proportionate universe is incompletely intelligible and that complete intelligibility is demanded." Further "besides Aquinas's five ways, there are as many other proofs of the existence of God as there are aspects of incomplete intelligibility in the universe of proportionate being."⁹³ Lonergan thus envisages his approach to proving the existence of God as entirely congruent with and in fact the foundation of Aquinas's approaches to the question. The second comment is to note that in enumerating the various consequences of his approach to the question of God, Lonergan rehearses in a few brief paragraphs the basic conclusions of his study

90. *Ibid.*, 695.

91. As Lonergan notes, the chapter on the self-affirmation of the knower is in fact central to his argument at this stage. *Ibid.*, 698: "It is a fair question, but to answer it a distinction has to be drawn between (1) affirming a link between other existence and God's and (2) affirming the other existence that is linked to God's existence. The second element lies in the affirmation of some reality: it took place in the chapter on self-affirmation, and it was expanded to the universe of proportionate being in subsequent chapters."

92. For a fuller exposition and analysis see Bernard Tyrrell, *Bernard Lonergan's Philosophy of God* (Notre Dame, IN: University of Notre Dame Press, 1974).

93. Lonergan, *Insight*, 701.

on grace and freedom in Aquinas.⁹⁴ Again we can grasp the continuity of Lonergan's position with that of Aquinas.

In the following chapter, on "special transcendent knowledge," Lonergan departs from the more familiar questions in relation to proving the existence of God, to ask what God is doing in relation to the problem of sin and evil.

Because God is omniscient, he knows man's plight. Because he is omnipotent, he can remedy it. Because he is good, he wills to do so. The fact of evil is not the whole story. It also is a problem. Because God exists, there is a further intelligibility to be grasped.⁹⁵

Here as a philosopher Lonergan cannot move beyond his brief to point to the Incarnation, redemption and the church as providing God's response to our plight. This would involve an appeal to revelation and hence be theological in the strict sense. However, as a philosopher he begins to speculate as to what a possible solution might look like, in order to establish an anticipation of the "heuristic structure" of a solution to the problem of evil. He specifies three possible solutions: a natural solution, a relatively supernatural solution, and an absolutely supernatural solution to the problem of evil. While there are differences between these, and as a philosopher one cannot pass judgment as to which is in fact operative in the actual universe of being, still each will involve three "conjugate forms" within human consciousness: faith in the intellect to believe in the solution offered by God and the various truths that emerge from it; hope in our conscious sensitivity to face the difficulties that emerge in living out the solution; and charity in the will which meets the fact of evil with self-sacrificing generosity, healing, and compassion. The fact that this aligns with the traditional theological virtues would escape the attention of no one. In his discussion of these conjugate forms Lonergan provides a long excursus on the nature of belief.⁹⁶ I shall engage with this more fully below, because it provides an excellent response to many of the questions that emerge around faith and reason lying at the heart of debates on the possibility of a Christian philosophy.

By any measure *Insight* is a philosophical masterpiece and the above material barely scratches its surface. Here Lonergan is not just seeking to "reach up to the mind of Aquinas" but to speak in his own voice,

94. Ibid., 684–87.

95. Ibid., 716.

96. Ibid., 725–40.

engaging what he had learnt in that reaching up to bring it to bear on our modern context. Aquinas knew nothing of the advances of modern science, whereas Lonergan regarded the modern scientific revolution as one of the most important cultural advances of our age.⁹⁷ Lonergan's comfort with both the content and method of science distinguishes him from the majority of his contemporary theologians and Thomistic philosophers for whom science remained an undiscovered country. Lonergan was also willing to engage with major philosophical trends, particularly the Kantian transcendental idealism and the Hegelian challenge of absolute idealism, not just view them as adversaries to be overcome.⁹⁸ Lonergan was clearly not unaware of the dangers Gilson identified in terms of a self-enclosed subjectivity knowing only its own thoughts and not reality. But as I noted in Chapter 1, Eric Mascall, himself influenced by Gilson, thought that Lonergan survived the charge of Kantian idealism.⁹⁹ Finally in this Lonergan's most philosophical work, in its concluding Chapter 20 and the epilogue that follows, we find Lonergan the theologian emerging, bringing theological questions into the discussion, mapping out a heuristic anticipation of theological issues that can only be fully addressed through revelation.¹⁰⁰ These concluding sections in a way provide the overall context and climax of the whole project. As Lonergan himself describes it, that project is not one of faith seeking understanding [*fides quaerens intellectum*], but of understanding seeking faith [*intellectus quaerens fidem*].¹⁰¹ Only in the light of faith can the dynamism of intellect toward being reach its final goal.

Integrating the Existential – an Augustinian Turn?

Though as I have indicated, *Insight* is a major philosophical achievement, it would be wrong to think that Lonergan's thought ceased to

97. In later writings Lonergan voices the opinion that the scientific revolution "outshines everything since the rise of Christianity and reduces the Renaissance and the Reformation to mere episodes, mere internal displacements, within the system of medieval Christendom." See "Theology in its new context," in *A Second Collection*, ed. William Ryan and Bernard Tyrrell (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1974), 55–67, at 56.

98. Mark Morelli has made a strong case for Lonergan's engagement with the Hegelian challenge. See Mark Morelli, "Lonergan's Debt to Hegel and the Appropriation of Critical Realism," in *Meaning and History in Systematic Theology: Essays in Honor of Robert Doran, SJ*, ed. John Dadosky (Marquette: Marquette University Press, 2009).

99. Eric Mascall, *The Openness of Being: Natural Theology Today* (London: Darton, Longman and Todd, 1971), 90.

100. Lonergan himself will describe *Insight* as a prolegomenon to his later work on theological method.

101. See Lonergan, *Insight*, 753: "a problem of evil . . . demands the transformation of self-reliant intelligence into an *intellectus quaerens fidem*."

develop after this work. While *Insight* represents the modern transposition of the work of Aquinas, we can also suggest that as Lonergan's thought developed, it is Augustine who becomes a stronger voice. We have already noted in the discussion of *Verbum* that Lonergan seeks to integrate the method of interiority found in Augustine with the more metaphysical account of cognition to be found in Aristotle and Aquinas.¹⁰² However, the world of interiority is not just one of thought, but also of feeling. Whereas affectivity gets less attention in *Insight*, it begins to emerge as a significant theme as Lonergan extends his range beyond the cognitional to the more existential scope of human living. If for Augustine it is our restless heart that rests not, until it rests in God, for the earlier Lonergan and for Aquinas, it is more the restlessness of our minds than never settles. Now in the post-*Insight* era Lonergan discovers (and thematizes) the restlessness of the heart. In his latter writings Lonergan will speak of feelings as providing the "mass, momentum, drive [and] power" of intentional consciousness.¹⁰³ Whereas *Insight* is dominated by the three-fold structure of experience, understanding and judgment, in later writings he will speak of *four* "transcendental precepts": "Be attentive, be intelligent, be reasonable, be responsible."¹⁰⁴ More and more the question of existential, rather than cognitional, authenticity comes to the fore. And rather than the question of God's existence being at the climax of the investigations, concerns with religious experience and religious conversion take a center stage.

These shifts are enormously enriching, filling out the more intellectualist stance of Lonergan's earlier work. Nonetheless none of these developments is a repudiation of his earlier gains; it is an expansion of Lonergan's horizon, an expansion which more fully prepares us for the movement into strictly theological concerns. However, for the sake of keeping some degree of control of the present project, on the possibility of a Christian philosophy, I shall keep the focus on his writings up to and including *Insight*, and whatever later writings may contribute to a better understanding of those works.

102. *Verbum*, 4.

103. *Method*, 30.

104. *Ibid.*, 231.

Lonergan as a “Christian Philosopher”

Now all would accept that Lonergan was a Christian and a philosopher. The question we now turn our attention to is whether we can think of him as a “Christian philosopher” more or less in the terms spelt out by Gilson in the previous chapter. Lonergan himself never used the term to describe his work, though he does adopt a perhaps related term “Christian realism,” which we shall consider below. And as we shall spell out more fully in the subsequent chapter there are philosophical differences between Gilson and Lonergan in terms of philosophy’s starting point (metaphysics or cognitional theory) as well as differences in their accounts of these two topics. Both however have claims to carrying on the tradition of Aquinas. These differences need further exploration. But in the meantime I would like to explore Lonergan’s credentials to be a Christian philosopher.

Natural Desire to see God¹⁰⁵

One of the major debates around the *nouvelle théologie* is the status of a purported “natural desire to see God.” Few questions have generated as much debate,¹⁰⁶ a debate that extends even into contemporary authors such as Lawrence Feingold¹⁰⁷ and John Milbank. As a question it touches on the range and scope of our orientation to the world of existence. Are we oriented to the source of all existence and if so is this orientation “natural” in the sense of a constitutive element in human nature, or is it supernatural, something implanted in us by God without which we would still be human, however diminished we might be? And so we have two questions: Does the scope of our orientation to the world extend to the source of the world, to God? Is this orientation natural or supernatural? The answer to the first is best captured by Augustine’s observation that our restless hearts can only truly rest in God. The answer to the second is where things get interesting.

Without exploring the depths of this debate I shall set forth Lonergan’s approach to the question. We have already seen how in *Insight*

105. For an excellent account of Lonergan’s position on this issue see Brian Himes, “Lonergan’s Position on the Natural Desire to See God and Aquinas’ Metaphysical Theology of Creation and Participation,” *Heythrop Journal* 54, no. 5 (2013): 767–83.

106. See for example the account of the debate surrounding the *nouvelle théologie* in Stephen Duffy, *The Graced Horizon: Nature and Grace in Modern Catholic Thought* (Collegeville, MN: Liturgical Press, 1992).

107. Lawrence Feingold, *The Natural Desire to See God According to St. Thomas Aquinas and His Interpreters* (Naples, FL: Sapientia Press of Ave Maria University, 2010).

Lonerган speaks of the detached disinterested desire to know, which has as its objective, being, everything that exists. This desire is a *potentia omnia*—a potency to all things, though of limited attainment. While the intentional reach of our questioning is all being, the actual attainment is of proportionate being. As Lonergan poses the question of God, does there exist transcendent being, being that transcends the reach of our actual attainment, and if so can we know of its existence? However, rather than start with *Insight* I will consider one of Lonergan's early Latin works, *De ente supernaturalis* (1946),¹⁰⁸ and the related article "On the Natural Desire to see God"¹⁰⁹ in which Lonergan considers the question of whether we possess "natural desire to see God." This question directly touches on problems raised by the *nouvelle théologie* debates on the grace-nature distinction.

Lonerган defines desire as "an appetite for, or an act of striving after an object that is absent or not possessed."¹¹⁰ Within the range of desires he distinguishes between "natural appetite, on the one hand, and appetitive acts, whether sensitive or intellectual, on the other." These latter appetitive acts are "elicited," that is, it "is an act of desiring some object; it is caused and specified by that object as apprehended . . . and so is found only in sensitive and intellectual beings."¹¹¹ In this sense the word natural, when speaking of a "natural desire," has a double meaning, that is, natural as distinct from elicited, and natural as distinct from supernatural. And so, to speak of a natural desire to see God is to say the desire is neither elicited nor supernatural.

In what then does the natural desire consist? Lonergan argues that natural desires are revealed by their acts and the acts which he identifies as revealing this natural desire are acts of questioning.

The radical inclination or tendency of the intellect is manifested principally by the occurrence of the question *quid sit* ('What is it?' or 'Why is it so?') and *an sit* ('Is it so?'), to which all other questions can ultimately be reduced. Such questioning is a natural activity. . . . If questioning is natural, then so is the antecedent desire from which it wells up.¹¹²

108. The Latin work is not yet available in Lonergan's Collected Works, but a detailed analysis of this work can be found in J. Michael Stebbins, *The Divine Initiative: Grace, World-order, and Human Freedom in the Early Writings of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1995). I draw from Stebbins's analysis.

109. Bernard J. F. Lonergan, "The Natural Desire to see God," in *Collection*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (Toronto: Toronto University Press, 1988), 81–91.

110. Stebbins, *The Divine Initiative*, 150.

111. *Ibid.*, 151.

112. *Ibid.*, 154.

And so for Lonergan, “the question, *quid sit Deus*, expresses a desire that naturally arises as soon as one knows the existence of God.”¹¹³ In summary then, “the intellect’s desire to know is at root a desire to know God.”¹¹⁴

The desire to know that Lonergan thus identifies as a desire for God becomes the central theme of *Insight*. It is manifest in questions for understanding and questions of judgment. This questioning drives all our science, mathematics, scholarship, philosophy and theology. Its proper object is being itself, with the desire to know constituting a “notion of being” within consciousness. Lonergan often refers to the desire to know as “detached and disinterested” to distinguish it from the various other desires/attachments which create a polyphony within consciousness. Human desires are “polymorphous” and it is a constant struggle to allow full reign to the desire to know. The desire to know is unrestricted, as revealed in our constant questioning and the never ending flow of books which fill our libraries. Attempts to limit the scope of questions are immediately overcome by further questioning of those limits. The desire to know is itself a “pure” question, a question without preconditions, without boundaries. Left to its own internal dynamism it will raise the question of God, and fidelity to that dynamism will lead one to inevitably affirm the existence of God. To properly grasp the significance of this desire to know is the core of all philosophy.¹¹⁵

The Possibility of Natural Knowledge of God

As we can see from above, not unrelated to the question of the natural desire to see God, is that of the possibility of natural knowledge of God. We have already witnessed Lonergan’s commitment to a natural theology in the concluding chapters of *Insight*. His proof of the existence of God comes as the culmination and climax of a moving viewpoint, which begins with cognitive theory and moves to epistemological and metaphysical accounts, in such a way that God’s existence is the ultimate underpinning of the intelligibility of reality. Without God, reality remains unintelligible and what is unintelligible falls away into non-existence. In more traditional terms God is the necessary ground of being for the universe of contingent being. Lonergan would view his

113. Lonergan, “The Natural Desire to see God,” 83.

114. Stebbins, *The Divine Initiative*, 155.

115. The references here to *Insight* are too numerous to list, but can easily be traced through the index to that work.

argument as fulfilling the teaching of Vatican I on the possibility of natural knowledge of God.

Still it is a “proof” that depends on pre-conditions and commitments, the culmination of a moving viewpoint, which includes the self-affirmation of the knower in chapter 11 of *Insight*. This viewpoint also requires the adoption of the three positions and a rejection of the counter-positions. In his later writings Lonergan will refer to these requirements as amounting to a need for “intellectual conversion.” In other writings he notes that, “One cannot prove the existence of God to a Kantian without first breaking his allegiance to Kant. One cannot prove the existence of God to a positivist without first converting him from positivism.”¹¹⁶ So in that sense the argument begins within a horizon with certain presuppositions which may not be present in every subject. If one does not accept these presuppositions the argument has no traction. As Tyrrell notes:

The extrapolation from restricted acts of understanding to the unrestricted act of understanding is a subtle and refined intellectual accomplishment doomed to failure from the outset unless attempted by one who is operating from the basis of fully developed intellectual conversion.¹¹⁷

This recognition marks a development on the standard Thomist position which tends to take somewhat for granted the correct disposition within the subject asking the question of God’s existence. Here the basic presuppositions of any proof for the existence of God are not the basic principles of being (such as the principles of non-contradiction and identity) but the correct alignment of our native orientation to being with our stance on knowing, objectivity and reality. In his later writings Lonergan shifts even further to claim that it is not the answer, but the question about God that is most significant, because it is our questions about God that provide a basic heuristic as to the meaning of the word God itself.¹¹⁸ What emerges here is that in the debate between faith and reason, there is an important distinction between the native operations of intellect (performance) and our accounts of the opera-

116. Bernard J. F. Lonergan, “The General Character of the Natural Theology of *Insight*,” in *Philosophical and Theological Papers 1965–1980*, ed. Robert M. Doran and Frederick E. Crowe, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2004), 6.

117. Tyrrell, *Bernard Lonergan’s Philosophy of God*, 136. Note the similarities with Taylor’s comments that a conclusion of an argument for the existence of God comes at the end of an “extreme and most fragile end of a chain of inferences.” Charles Taylor, *A Secular Age* (Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press, 2007), 558.

118. Lonergan, *Method*, 101–3.

tions of intellect (reflection on performance). When we talk about reason we often have in mind some account of what reason is, which may or may not accurately grasp the actual performance of intellect. This is very evident in debates with the “new atheists” who often put forward an empiricist or positivist account of reason, as if that is what reason actually is. Further, a distorted account of reason feeds back into our own performance, distorting our reasoning in the process. Without attending to these “subjective” aspects of proving the existence of God, we can find our intellectual wheels spinning but nothing moves forward.

Cognitive Theory or Metaphysics

In reviewing his achievement in *Insight*, it is clear that Lonergan is well aware that he is breaking with the received tradition in taking cognitive theory as his starting point. Indeed he notes that “the most shocking aspect of the book, *Insight*, is the primacy it accords to knowledge” while “in the writings of St Thomas, cognitive theory is expressed in metaphysical terms and established by metaphysical principles.” As he states in it, “I have turned everything upside down.”¹¹⁹ On the other hand, as he does in his more fulsome study, *Verbum*, he identifies times in the work of Aquinas where an appeal is made to our experience of cognitive processes. In particular he quotes *STh* I q88, a2, ad3, which he translates as “the human soul understands itself by its understanding, which is its proper act, perfectly demonstrating its power and its nature.”¹²⁰ He goes further to justify this appeal to experience by using the standard Aristotelian and Thomist distinction between the *quoad se* (what is first in itself) and *quoad nos* (what is first for us). While being is first in itself, knowing is first for us. If we take the *quoad se* as a starting point, then metaphysics has priority over cognitive theory; however if we take the *quoad nos* as a starting point, then cognitive theory takes precedence. Both are equally valid starting points, however, and both lead to isomorphic conclusions. As he notes, “on this showing, then, the ontological and the cognitive are not incompatible alternatives but interdependent procedures.”¹²¹ He further appeals to the needs of the present day to go beyond the desire to “select a minimum number of certitudes on which all agree,

119. “*Insight*: Preface to a Discussion,” in *Collection*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 1993), 142.

120. *Ibid.*, 143.

121. *Ibid.*, 144.

to strive for a thorough knowledge of medieval thought, to deduce new conclusions from old premises" all drawn from the writings of Aristotle and Aquinas. Rather there is a need to implement "Aristotelian and Thomist method." This demands "a developed understanding of understanding itself, and to use that developed understanding of human understanding to bring order and light and unity to a totality of disciplines and modes of knowledge."¹²²

Lonerган's relationship then to the position of Aquinas is not one of repetition, but of transposition. In the light of so many modern developments—the emergence of modern science,¹²³ of historical consciousness,¹²⁴ of the turn to the subject¹²⁵—simple repetition is not enough. While there are undoubtedly dangers in such an approach, amply spelt out by Gilson in the previous chapter, there are also many gains to be had, particularly for a Christian philosophy that will need to deal with questions of religious experience. The Christian tradition is replete with explorations of the interior life, be it Augustine, Ignatius of Loyola or the Rhineland mystics. Lonergan was himself a son of Ignatius, and there are those who argue that his own method finds its grounding in the Ignatian spiritual exercises.¹²⁶ Such a turn to the concrete experience of the subject runs the risk not so much of idealism, but of blurring the distinction between grace and nature. I shall return to this issue in the final chapter.

The Reasonableness of Believing

As I noted in chapter 1, if you want to develop a more precise account of the relationship between faith and reason, one must first provide a fairly precise account of reason, in order to be able to differentiate it from faith. Lonergan provides just such a precise account of reason through his structure of experience, understanding and judgment. However, he pushes the matter further by providing a far more

122. *Ibid.*, 145.

123. Here Lonergan concurs with the judgment of the historian of science, Herbert Butterfield, that the emergence of modern science "outshines everything since the rise of Christianity and reduces the Renaissance and the Reformation to mere episodes, mere internal displacements, within the system of medieval Christendom." "Theology in its New Context," 56. Lonergan is referring to Herbert Butterfield, *The Origins of Modern Science, 1300–1800*, 2nd ed. (New York: Free Press, 1966).

124. See Bernard J. F. Lonergan, "The Transition from a Classicist World-View to Historical Mindedness," in *A Second Collection*, ed. William F. Ryan and Bernard Tyrrell (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1974).

125. "The Subject."

126. Robert Doran, "Ignatian Themes in the Thought of Bernard Lonergan," *Toronto Journal of Theology* 22, no. 1 (2006): 39–54.

nuanced and precise account of faith as well, in a way that takes the debate in a surprising direction. To those who would oppose faith and reason, especially those who promote reason against faith, Lonergan demonstrates the reasonableness of believing. Without some form of belief all that we can claim to know is that which we ourselves can generate from our own experience, understanding and judgment. In fact if that is all we can legitimately claim to know, in the strict sense, if belief were to be excluded, we would all be most ignorant. Indeed most of what we claim to “know” is not immanently generated at all, but is material we take “on trust” as part of the common store of knowledge offered to us through our education, reading, and heritage. These are the general plausibility structures and background beliefs constitutive of a society or particular community. For Lonergan, the “general context of belief is the collaboration of mankind in the advancement and the dissemination of knowledge.”¹²⁷ Without such belief we would be condemned to primitivism.¹²⁸

As with his account of cognition, Lonergan also provides a precise account of the stages that lead to a belief:

Five stages are to be distinguished, namely, (1) preliminary judgments on the value of belief in general, on the reliability of the source for this belief, and on the accuracy of the communication from the source, (2) a reflective act of understanding that, in virtue of the preliminary judgments, grasps as virtually unconditioned the value of deciding to believe some particular proposition, (3) the consequent judgment of value, (4) the consequent decision of the will, and (5) the assent that is the act of believing.¹²⁹

If we focus on the first of these stages, two important elements emerge. The first is a general judgment of the value of belief in general. Belief permeates all our attempts to know. The scientist who thought it necessary to recapitulate all previous scientific discoveries for herself before she could made a genuine advance of her own would be a scientist who never made an advance!¹³⁰ Those physicists working at the Large Hadron Collider believe all the theoretical and practical intel-

127. Lonergan, *Insight*, 725.

128. It is the startling discovery that much of what we think we “know” is in fact a matter of belief that leaves the door open for the very modern phenomenon of widespread suspicion of generally trustworthy authorities. This is very evident in the climate change debate where large portions of the population feel justified in questioning and rejecting the scientific consensus on climate change.

129. Lonergan, *Insight*, 729–30.

ligence of the engineers who built their massive device. In our more mundane daily lives we believe in the theoretical and practical intelligence of those who build our cars, our electrical and electronic devices, and so on. If we had to verify for ourselves all the insights that went into producing them all before we trusted their operation, life would be a tedious and dull affair. As Lonergan notes, belief allows for “the collaboration of mankind in the advancement and the dissemination of knowledge.”¹³¹ The second element is that belief involves *someone* believed. Any act of belief involves a judgment as to the trustworthiness of the one we believe. Is this a reliable person? Have they communicated the facts accurately? Belief then is always about an interpersonal relationship to some degree. We may trust the other person’s professionalism or simply their virtue.

Clearly believing is not infallible. We can and do have false beliefs. “Mistaken beliefs exist, and the function of an analysis of belief is overlooked if it fails to explain how mistaken beliefs arise and how they are to be eliminated.”¹³² Rather than reject the contribution of belief to our knowing, Lonergan counsels a methodology for eliminating false belief:

It takes as its starting point and clue the discovery of some precise issue on which undoubtedly one was mistaken. It advances by inquiring into the sources that may have contributed to that error and, perhaps, contributed to other errors as well. It asks about the motives and the supporting judgments that, as they once confirmed one in that error, may still be holding one in others. It investigates the consequences of the view one now rejects, and it seeks to determine whether or not they too are to be rejected. The process is cumulative. The discovery of one error is exploited to lead to the discovery of others; and the discovery of the others provides a still larger base to proceed to the discovery of still more.¹³³

Lonergan is taking forward a suggestion of Newman, that it is better to believe everything, and set about correcting false belief, than to adopt the universal doubt of Descartes which runs the risk of emptying the mind of essential knowledge along with error.¹³⁴

Lonergan’s argument for the rationality of belief cuts across the dichotomy of faith and reason so prevalent in many current debates,

130. As one example Lonergan gives states, “Perhaps no one has immanently generated knowledge that general relativity is more accurate than Newtonian theory on the perihelion of Mercury. But it does not follow that for everyone it is purely a matter of belief.” *Ibid.*, 728.

131. *Ibid.*, 725.

132. *Ibid.*, 735.

133. *Ibid.*, 736.

134. “Universal doubt leads the philosopher to reject what he is not equipped to restore.” *Ibid.*, 436.

particularly in the science-religion context. It is a reminder that even the “knowledge” of the scientist is suffused with belief.¹³⁵ In contexts of both science and religion people can make a reasonable decision to believe others, based on our assessment of their reliability and the value of believing in general as a way of transmitting knowledge from one person to another. What is important is that someone actually knows in the chain of believing.

Christian Realism

While Lonergan does not directly use the term “Christian philosophy” of his own position, he uses a similar and perhaps more precise term, that of “Christian realism” to identify a position he finds congruent with his own thinking. What we can grasp in this designation is the close connection operating between doctrinal commitments and philosophical outcomes, all the time maintaining the clear distinction between faith and reason, between theology and philosophy. Lonergan argues that Christian doctrine contains an implicit realism which becomes increasingly explicit in the history of Christian theological attempts to understand these doctrines. Just as Gilson draws philosophical implications from the story of Exodus 3:14, Lonergan will draw on various theological positions to make explicit implications that can philosophically stand in their own right.

Impact of Christology

The first example arises from autobiographical comments Lonergan made in relation to his own intellectual development. These comments have been brought together in William Mathews’s book, *Lonergan’s Quest*, and in Richard Liddy’s book, *Transforming Light*.¹³⁶ As noted by these authors Lonergan attributes his own grasp of the distinction between essence and existence to working through a serious dogmatic question in theology:

135. This is very evident in the climate change debate. It is not unreasonable to believe the position of climate scientists on the basis of their special expertise. Even other scientists will trust their judgments and the process of scientific peer review that supports their research. But few actually have the immanently generated knowledge about climate change. In later works Lonergan refers to this insight as to do with the “sociology of knowledge” as propounded by Peter L. Berger and Thomas Luckmann, *The Social Construction of Reality: a Treatise in the Sociology of Knowledge* (New York: Anchor Books, 1990).

136. Mathews, *Lonergan’s Quest*, 82–84; Richard M. Liddy, *Transforming Light: Intellectual Conversion in the early Lonergan* (Collegeville, Minn.: Liturgical Press, 1993), 114–16.

Can one have one person who has two natures? The argument given me by a good Thomist, Father Bernard Leeming, was that if you have a real distinction between *esse* (existence) and essence, the *esse* can be the ground of the person and of the essence too. If the *esse* is relevant to two essences, then you can have one person in two natures. On that basis I solved the problem of Christ's consciousness: one subject and two subjectivities.¹³⁷

Now the question of the person and natures of Christ is something that could not be known unless it were revealed to us; on this both Gilson and Lonergan would concur. While Gilson finds the distinction between essence and existence in the revelation of the divine name, for Lonergan the basic dogmatic formulation of Chalcedon is rendered unintelligible without such a distinction. For both thinkers what drives the emergence of the distinction is not just abstract philosophical reasoning, but personal engagement with revelation within a context of an historical practice of such engagement. Still, both would hold that as something knowable in itself, the distinction is a purely philosophical position that is at least potentially accessible through reason alone. I shall return to this example below in discussing Lonergan's notion of Christian realism.

The Relationship Between Trinitarian Theology and Epistemology

The second example is in relation to the role of Trinitarian theology in Lonergan's philosophical development. In the epilogue to *Insight* Lonergan notes that his position in that work draws on his historical study of the work of Aquinas: "So it is that my detailed investigations of the thought of Aquinas on *gratia operans* and on *verbum* have been followed by the present essay in aid of a personal appropriation of one's own rational self-consciousness."¹³⁸ Yet both these works depend heavily on Christian dogmatic teachings: the first on grace and free will; the second on the Trinity. To focus on the second of these, Lonergan's work, *Verbum: Word and Idea in Aquinas*, is often related to by philosophers for its rejection of Scotist conceptualism, its affirmation of Aquinas's intellectualism, and for its proposed resolution of questions in Thomist epistemology. Now it is undoubtedly true that these elements are to be found in that work. However, the immediate question that Lonergan is seeking to address, as we have noted above, is that of the Trinitarian processions. He begins the work with some general comments about

137. Mathews, *Lonergan's Quest*, 82.

138. Lonergan, *Insight*, 769.

the then state of play in relation to the question of the Trinitarian processions. He notes the conflict between those who hold that the procession of the Word may be found in the “sensitive potency” in contrast to those who hold it may only be found in the intellect. He identifies the difference between these two positions as arising from a “neglect of what is peculiar to rational creatures.” He concludes, “I believe these questions to be significant. It is to discuss them that I have undertaken the present inquiry into the concept of *verbum* in the writings of St Thomas.”¹³⁹

In undertaking this study Lonergan is engaging in a practice of reflection going back at least as far as Augustine’s *De Trinitate*. This practice is driven by a theological desire to find some way of approaching the doctrine of the Trinity in an intellectually coherent manner, not in order to prove it as a doctrine, but to make sense of what is believed (*fides quaerens intellectum*). This practice seeks analogies for the two divine processions in various operations within human consciousness. Yet in order for the analogy to work as an analogy various philosophical assumptions must be in place. For example, unless knowing attains reality, the analogy for the divine Word proceeding from the Father as a concept proceeds from an act of understanding, cannot help us understand how the Word is consubstantial with the Father. Similarly unless judgments of value are grounded in reason, the analogy cannot help us understand how the Spirit proceeds from the Father and the Son.¹⁴⁰

What we find here is an intimate connection between revelation and philosophical development in Lonergan’s work. Dogmatic belief in the Trinity is driving greater and greater precision in relation to questions of cognitional structure and epistemology through the speculative hypothesis of the psychological analogy. This precision could be derived from reason alone, but more obscurely and with greater difficulty. In fact in *Insight* we can witness the effort needed to attain some of these positions on the basis of philosophical reason alone. However, from the point of view of the present discussion, what is important is the way in which this element of Lonergan’s work exemplifies Gilson’s notion of a Christian philosophy.

139. *Verbum*, 13.

140. For a fuller account of the philosophical assumptions embedded in the psychological analogy see Neil Ormerod, “The Psychological Analogy for the Trinity – At Odds with Modernity,” *Pacifica* 14 (2001): 281–94.

Origins of Christian Realism

In an essay entitled, "The Origins of Christian Realism," Lonergan develops further this interaction between dogmatic teaching and philosophical thought.¹⁴¹ This essay was written in response to certain proposals by Ansfried Hulsbosch, Edward Schillebeeckx and Piet Schoonenberg for a revision of Christological doctrine. Lonergan meets these proposals with a discussion of Christianity's engagement with the problems of realism since the time of the early Trinitarian and Christological debates. He outlines how Christianity is inextricably involved in the problems of realism. In fact, Christian meanings demand a critical, or at least, dogmatic realism to make sense of its basic doctrines. And so, after reviewing the distinction between the world of immediacy and the world mediated by meaning, he considers the early Trinitarian debates, to grasp how different philosophical positions handle the question of the relationship between the Father and the Son. The way in which to understand "what was moving forward" is, he argues, to observe that Tertullian was a naïve realist, that Origen was a neo-Platonic idealist, while Athanasius, and the definition of Nicaea, demand at least a dogmatic realism, to be able to properly affirm the *homoousios*. This realism is based on accepting the assertion that reality corresponds to true meaning, mediated by propositions, as summarized in the Athanasian rule for the *homoousios*: "all that is said of the Father also is to be said of the Son, except that the Son is Son and not the Father."¹⁴² Such a formulation operates within a world mediated by meaning but is problematic as long as one remains within the world of immediacy.

Turning to Christological doctrine Lonergan then seeks to explain the distinction between person and nature in the Chalcedonian definition by considering three meanings of the term "one." There is one, in the numerical sense, corresponding to experiential activity. There is one, grasped in terms of the unity of a thing, corresponding to intellectual activity. And then there is one, as in one and the same, as distinct from another, corresponding to judging. Here Lonergan is clearly

141. Lonergan, "The Origins of Christian Realism."

142. Ibid., 250. The reference to Athanasius is to his *Against the Arians*, Discourse III.4. Lonergan develops the same point more fully in *The Way to Nicaea: the Dialectical Development of Trinitarian Theology*, trans. Conn O'Donovan (London: Darton, Longman & Todd, 1976). This material is now available in its fuller context of Lonergan's work on the Trinity, *The Triune God: Doctrines*, ed. Robert M. Doran and H. Daniel Monsour, trans. Michael Shields, Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2009).

invoking the three levels of cognitional structure in a way that transposes into cognitional terms the classical distinction between essence and existence. Person is then defined in terms of the one and the same identity affirmed in judgment. This account gives more precision to his autobiographical comments noted earlier that the distinction between person and nature in the Chalcedonian definition requires a real distinction between existence (grounded in judgment) and essence (grounded in understanding).

Lonergan makes this connection, between religious experience and belief on the one hand, and philosophical development on the other, explicit in his notions of religious and intellectual conversion. In *Method in Theology* Lonergan speaks of religious conversion in terms of an other-worldly falling in love, the gift of God's love poured into our hearts by the Holy Spirit (Rom 5:5). This experience of God's love grounds faith as a knowledge borne of that love. This faith is expressed as religious beliefs which are the cultural and historical expression of that faith. As we can see in the above examples, for Lonergan the teachings of Nicea and Constantinople elicit an intellectual conversion as the depths of that revelation are uncovered through the ongoing reflection of the Christian community. As Lonergan states it:

First there is God's gift of his love. Next, the eye of this love reveals values in their splendor, while the strength of this love brings about their realization, and that is moral conversion. Finally, *among the values discerned by the eye of love is the value of believing the truths taught by the religious tradition, and in such tradition and belief are the seeds of intellectual conversion.* For the word, spoken and heard, proceeds from and penetrates to all four levels of intentional consciousness. Its content is not just a content of experience but a content of experience and understanding and judging and deciding. The analogy of sight yields the cognitional myth. But fidelity to the word engages the whole man. [emphasis added]¹⁴³

In summary then we have noted a number of ways in which Lonergan conceives the interaction of philosophical reasoning with revealed truths. In terms that MacIntyre might use we can say that revelation initiates, prolongs and sustains a tradition of rationality we can locate in the philosophical realism of the Thomistic tradition, and its modern transposition in the work of Lonergan. This achieves, I would argue, what Gilson sought to articulate in his notion of a Christian philosophy, even though Lonergan himself does not use the term.

143. *Method*, 243.

Lonergan on Gilson

In the previous chapter I outlined Gilson's critique of the turn to the subject, as exemplified by the transcendental Thomists of the Leuven school. Many have seen this critique as extending to the position of Lonergan as spelt out above. Lonergan is a strong proponent of the turn to the subject, taking as his starting point cognitional theory to ground his metaphysics. In fairness we should also present Lonergan's account of Gilson, in order to place it within a Lonerganian perspective. Now Lonergan has not provided us with extensive commentary on Gilson's work, but he did write two essays, a book review of *Being and Some Philosophers*,¹⁴⁴ and an essay entitled "Metaphysics as Horizon," a critical response to work of Emerich Coreth.¹⁴⁵

Lonergan is clearly appreciative of Gilson's work in *Being and Some Philosophers*. He describes it as "extraordinarily erudite" and as containing an "amazing wealth of insights."¹⁴⁶ After presenting a summary of the argument of the book and noting a few areas of disagreement, Lonergan expresses his agreement with the "central contentions" of the work: "Being is existing, and thinking is not knowing." In so arguing he has placed "the old disputed question of essence and existence" into a new context by Gilson's appeal to the historical experiment of past philosophies: "For an appeal to history as experiment is not more argument or more theory. It is an appeal to fact and possesses the peculiar decisiveness of that appeal."¹⁴⁷ Indeed it may be that Gilson's historical method here provided Lonergan with something of a model for his own brief discussion of "Theories of the Notion of Being" and his fuller discussion of "The Dialectic of Method in Metaphysics" in *Insight*,¹⁴⁸ though both go back in some way to Aristotle's use of historical dialectic in philosophy.

As Lonergan notes the decisive step in Gilson's argument is the role of judgment. As he quotes Gilson, "'All real knowledge includes a judgment of existence' (p. 204)." Judgment moves us beyond substantial form, individuating matter, and accidents to "a further ontological

144. "Review of Étienne Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*," in *Shorter Papers*, ed. Robert Croken, Robert M. Doran, and H. Daniel Monsour, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto, 2007), 185–88. The original review appeared in 1950 in *Theological Studies*.

145. "Metaphysics as Horizon," in *Collection*, ed. Frederick E. Crowe and Robert M. Doran, *Collected Works of Bernard Lonergan* (Toronto: University of Toronto, 1988), 188–204. The original article was published in 1963 in *Gregorianum*.

146. "Review of Étienne Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*," 185.

147. *Ibid.*, 188.

148. *Insight*, 388–98, 426–55.

component named ‘existence’.” Nonetheless Lonergan expresses some concern about Gilson’s precise understanding of the act of judgment: “Finally, the insistence upon a ‘return to sense’ and the affirmation of an intuitive experience of acts of existing (pp. 206–7) are strangely reminiscent of something like Kierkegaard’s aesthetic sphere of existential subjectivity.”¹⁴⁹ Still he does not view this quibble as invalidating Gilson’s overall argument.

In his later essay, “Metaphysics as Horizon” we find a more extended and critical engagement with Gilson’s earlier work, *Thomistic Realism and the Critique of Knowledge*. The context of this engagement is an extended review of the work of Coreth in developing a transcendental metaphysics. Coreth’s project is within what he identifies as “transcendental Thomism” as exemplified by the Leuven Thomists that Gilson has so thoroughly critiqued in his work *Thomistic Realism*. Lonergan engages in a three-way dialectic between Coreth, Kant, and Gilson, to highlight the similarities and differences between the three approaches. Lonergan is clearly far more sympathetic to the approach of Coreth, which in many ways parallels his own. In relation to Gilson, however, he makes a number of critical comments.

Firstly he compares Gilson’s appeal to perception to Kant’s notion of *Anschauung* or “intuition.” Both provide these philosophers with a door to the real world, in an attempt to provide some basis for objectivity. For Kant this basis must fail because our *Anschauung* is only sensitive (phenomenal) and so does not reach the thing-in-itself (*noumena*). Human knowing is then confined to the phenomena. Gilson avoids this idealist trap by his assertion that there exists “an intellectual vision of the concept of being in any sensible datum . . . predicated in perceptual judgments of existence.”¹⁵⁰ For Gilson there can be no mediation of the real, for any such meditation leads inevitably to idealism and the problem of the bridge—how to get the outside inside. “It follows that [for Gilson] realism is possible if and only if we *perceive* reality.”¹⁵¹ As we noted in the previous chapter, Gilson himself refers to this position as a dogmatic realism, indeed “the brute reaffirmation of dogmatic real-

149. “Review of Étienne Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*,” 187. The page references within the quote are to Étienne Gilson, *Being and Some Philosophers*, 2nd ed. (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Mediaeval Studies, 1952).

150. Lonergan, “Metaphysics as Horizon,” 195.

151. *Ibid.*, 196.

ism, the validity of which had been denied by Kant's critique."¹⁵² In this way Gilson can save the objectivity of human knowing.

However, what can be dogmatically asserted can equally dogmatically be denied, so how are we to decide between the Kantian and Gilsonian position? Coreth provides an alternative approach, one congruent with Lonergan's own position in *Insight*. Lonergan takes as his starting point two different ways of reading the Thomist principle, *Nihil in intellectu nisi prius fuerit in sensu* (nothing in the intellect unless first in sense). He notes however there is a difference between a box being empty and a stomach being empty. "When there is nothing in a box, a box does not feel empty; when there is nothing in a stomach, the stomach does feel empty. Human intelligence is more like a stomach than a box."¹⁵³ While empty, the mind still can ask questions, and "the analysis of questioning forces one to conceive of human intelligence, not on the analogy of sense, but properly in terms of intelligence itself."¹⁵⁴ While for Gilson being is perceived through the senses, for Coreth and Lonergan being is intended in questions that arise from the sense data. This "intention of being" in questioning is an *a priori* within the subject that eliminates the problem of the bridge: "there can be no problem of the 'extramental,' of getting outside the mind, for as soon as a question is asked, being is intended, being includes everything, and so everything is already within the mind's intention."¹⁵⁵ In terms Lonergan uses in *Insight*, Gilson's position is based on an extroverted conception of reality as already-out-there-now, a counter-position inviting reversal through attention to the dynamic intention of being found in human questioning.

This is not to say that Lonergan endorses the whole of Coreth's program, and the point of disagreement is instructive for the present work. Coreth is seeking to define metaphysics as a basic position that "accepts no presuppositions that it itself does not justify."¹⁵⁶ As we have seen however in *Insight*, for Lonergan metaphysics is a derived science, one whose ultimate basis lies in cognitional theory.

152. Étienne Gilson, *Thomist Realism and the Critique of Knowledge* (San Francisco: Ignatius Press, 2012), 154.

153. Lonergan, "Metaphysics as Horizon," 200.

154. *Ibid.*, 201.

155. *Ibid.*, 202.

156. *Ibid.*, 189.

Conclusion

As with Gilson, Lonergan has had his share of critics, not least among them those who have taken the Gilsonian critique to heart. Given the diversity of Lonergan's writings, in theology, philosophy, economics, art, education to name a few, critics can find ample points of disagreement and criticism. The one constant in all Lonergan's work is the turn to the subject, the exploration of interiority or human consciousness. This is the basis on which his life's work stands or falls. Nonetheless, in contrast with the faltering reception of Gilson's legacy, the reception of Lonergan's work remains relatively robust, both philosophically and theologically. While much of the early reception focused on his philosophical contributions, increasingly Lonergan's theological work is being taken up.¹⁵⁷ Lonergan's *Insight* and its related works have a certain timeless quality to them that transcends much of their historical and cultural context. They are likely to continue to provoke both admiration and dissent for some time to come. While I have already indicated some mutual dialogue between our two thinkers, it is now time for a more thorough engagement between them with a particular focus on whether Lonergan falls under the Gilsonian critique of idealism and their potential common ground in relation to the possibility of a Christian philosophy.

157. To my mind this theological reception has been greatly facilitated by the writings of Robert Doran.